Flares of Doubt

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/68602606.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Hurt/Comfort, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Soft Catra (She-Ra), Magic, Post-Canon, Angst with a Happy Ending, Light Angst

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-08-03 Completed: 2025-08-27 Words: 12,158 Chapters: 16/16

Flares of Doubt

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/68602606.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Hurt/Comfort, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Soft Catra (She-Ra), Magic, Post-Canon, Angst with a Happy Ending, Light Angst

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-08-03 Completed: 2025-08-27 Words: 12,158
Chapters: 16/16

Flares of Doubt

by NotMyDestiny

Summary

The magic was released from the Heart back to Etheria, but despite the peace and beauty it seemed to bring there are signs that it may not be fully stabilized and She-Ra may be needed again.

Chapter 1

Etheria was blooming more now than it had in over a thousand years. The air glistened with a near constant golden light, an echo of the magic that had so recently been released from the Heart. The shimmer in the air softened each sunrise into a pastel rainbow glow that lingered throughout the sky. Trees were growing more majestic and rivers were running clearer as they bubbled with renewed vigor. Radiant flowers bloomed over the rolling meadows surrounding Bright Moon in blankets of the brightest colors.

The world was fully breathing again, and for the first time in as long as either of them could remember, Adora and Catra were breathing with it. The two were perched on a ledge of smooth stone overlooking the valley, just outside the castle grounds. Their legs stretched out and lazily tangled together. The light of late morning poured over them, warm and sweet and slow. Catra leaned back on her elbows, squinting at the sun, her hair catching glints of amber in the light. Adora sat close, her knee touching Catra's, one hand curled around a mug of warm tea.

Adora took in a soft breath. "This still feels kind of unreal."
Catra cracked an eye back open and the corner of her mouth tugged upward. "You say that every morning."
"Well… it does." Adora gestured to the horizon, where the soft rolling hills seemed to pulse with life and distant flocks of feathered birds passed by overhead. "After everything we've been through… Horde Prime, the Heart… it's just…" Her voice trailed off, lost in the breeze.
Catra tilted her head to the side, watching Adora with an affectionate gaze and a teasing glint in her eye. "You mean after nearly dying repeatedly and carrying a planet's worth of magic in your bones, now you get to watch birds with sparkles on their wings?"
Adora laughed and nudged her lightly. "I'm trying to be serious."
"I am being serious," Catra said, grinning. "You deserve boring Adora. You deserve sparkly birds and too many flowers and

awkward brunches with your princess friends."
Adora leaned her head against Catra's shoulder. "We both do."
For a long minute, the two sat there wrapped in the hush of the land and the beauty all around them. It felt like peace. Or at least the beginning of it.

Then, from somewhere deeper in the valley, a sudden gust of wind broke through the stillness. It sent a rush of magic through the trees, too fast, like a shiver. A flash of violet shimmered in the distance, quick and pulsing.
Catra sat up instantly, ears twitching. "Did you just see that?"
Adora frowned, following her gaze. "Yeah. That was definitely odd."

They stood without speaking, eyes on the forest ridge beyond the river. It had died down just as quickly as it had come, but now the valley seemed unsettled like the air had been stirred too deeply.
"Probably just a magical echo," Adora said after a moment, trying to regain the calm. "The magic's still adjusting. Glimmer said it might be like that."
Catra's tail flicked. "Yeah, or something out there is pissed."
Adora gave her a look. "Do you have to say it like that?"
Catra smirked, but there was a crease between her brows now. "Tell me I'm wrong."
Adora didn't.

They walked back slowly, not talking much. The peace of the morning proving more fragile than they had hoped.

Chapter 2

The council chamber at Bright Moon seemed calmer than ever before. The long crystal windows were open to the breeze and sunlight spilled across the floor in golden patterns. The table had fresh fruit and bread in the center instead of war map simulations. Even the walls seemed recharged with restored Etherian magic humming faintly within. But beneath the surface was a current of something quieter and more cautious.

"We've confirmed three more anomalies in the past two days," Glimmer said, frowning at a glowing tracker pad. "Two were harmless. Just overgrowth where trees sprouted from nothing and vines wrapped a whole tower in a matter of hours. But the third…" She looked up, eyes darkening slightly. "It was like a shockwave. It was a pulse of magic that flattened an entire clearing."
Adora shifted in her seat. "Like what Catra and I saw yesterday?"
"Possibly," Bow said tapping his own tracker pad, which projected a small glowing map of Etheria with several red points blinking. "The energy signature I'm detecting is unstable. It seems unpredictable. We think these magic flares are coming from something deeper. Something still tied to the Heart."
"And it's strongest out near the western forest," Glimmer added.

Catra leaned back with her arms crossed and her tail twitching against her chair. "So what? You want us to go and poke the weird glowing forest ghost?"
"Investigate," Glimmer said dryly. "Not poke."
"I don't know. I kind of like the idea of poking it," Adora said with a sheepish grin. Then rubbing the back of her neck, she questioned hopefully, "I mean, it could just be nothing, right? Just leftover magic figuring itself out?"
"Or it could be the start of something bigger," Frosta cut in, her voice more serious than usual. "We don't know what Etheria's magic wants now that it's free. Or what it remembers."

The room fell silent for a moment.
Adora glanced sideways at Catra. She caught the tension in her

posture, the slight narrowing of her eyes, and the way her hand rested near the hilt of the knife on her belt as if readying for whatever was next.
Catra met her gaze and raised an eyebrow. “You’re gonna say yes, aren’t you?”
Adora hesitated, but only for a second. “Yeah. I think we should go.”
Glimmer gave a small nod of approval. “We’re not asking you to go alone. We’ll keep you connected by tracker pad. Bow and I can support from here with scans and teleport if anything goes wrong.”
“Great,” Catra muttered, rising to her feet. “Love being sent back into the magical forest where trees breathe funny and things glow when you’re not looking.”
Adora grinned as she stood beside her. “You never know, it could be fun.”
Catra gave her a look. “You and I have wildly different definitions of fun.” But she didn’t argue.

As the meeting wound down, the sun drifted higher outside the window, and Etheria sparkled with an impossible kind of beauty. It had been restored and renewed, but it seemed it wasn’t yet stable. And, near the wild edges of the map, magic rippled again too faint to be measured and too ancient to name. The Alliance had won the war, but the land itself was still waking up.

Chapter 3

They stepped out of Bright Moon castle with light gear ready to head into the western forest. The sky was a bright brilliant blue, and Adora tilted her face up into it, her eyes squinting as she let the sun wash over her and warm her skin. "It's nice to be going on a scouting mission with you instead of into a battle."
Catra, walking a step behind her snorted. "You say that like the forest isn't full of possibly cursed magic weirdness."
Adora grinned. "Oh, come on. We'll just check it out and report back, and maybe see some glowy mushrooms. It'll be easy."
"I don't trust anything that glows for no reason," Catra retorted.

They took a trail out of Bright Moon that wound its way toward the edge of the western wilds. The path had started off familiar with mossy stones and little birds flitting from branch to branch. It had felt like the Etheria they knew. As they hiked deeper into the woods, the trees grew taller and stranger and the light filtered through their leaves in a way that made shimmering patterns dance along the trail at their feet. They traveled light with just cloaks and simple packs with water and protein bars. Catra insisted on bringing a blade just in case.

As the sun rose higher in the sky, the two were laughing together as they made their way across a bubbling creek, their boots slipping on wet stones.
"You almost went down," Catra said smugly, steadying Adora with a careful hand on her arm.
"I had it," Adora insisted playfully, though her foot had absolutely skidded and she was still gripping Catra's shoulder tightly.
"Sure you did." Catra crooned leaning in closer. "You're just lucky I'm here to rescue you."
Adora gave her a soft look, and everything felt light in that moment like maybe the world really had been made whole again.

As they hiked further though, the air began to feel a bit strange. The light didn't change exactly, but it started to feel off. It was too shimmery and too still. The birds had fallen silent and even the

breezes seemed to have stopped. The tree trunks themselves seemed to almost glow.
"Do you feel that?" Catra asked, pausing in the middle of the trail. Her voice had dropped to a warier tone.
Adora slowed beside her. "Yeah."
The ground hummed a little, like a breath being held, like something was waiting. Then, in the distance across a wide stretch of lowland thick with ferns, they could see a pulse of golden light rise up from the trees. It flickered once and then disappeared.
"That's one of the flares," Adora said, staring wide eyed. "It has to be."
"Thought it was supposed to be subtle," Catra muttered.

They kept going, but slower now and more cautious. They were more hesitant as if not sure the ground ahead would really hold. The beauty around them was still mesmerizing. There were brilliantly colored flowers blooming off tree trunks and vines curling in tight spirals. But, there were also thorns poking out beneath them. It seemed like candy laced with poison, too good to be true and with something dangerous tangled within the beauty.

By the time they made camp near a grove of odd iridescent willows, the light was beginning to bend more strangely still. Shadows warped and crawled up tree trunks in what felt like almost the wrong direction.
Adora sat on a fallen log, and frowned uneasily, feeling a bit unsettled. "I thought this would be easier. I thought…"
Catra knelt beside her, pulling out their protein bars. "You thought we'd just go off on a nature walk and solve the magic instantly."
Adora laughed, but it didn't quite reach her eyes. "Is that so ridiculous?"
Catra glanced up at the trees, which now seemed to breathe faintly. "Yeah," she said. "But it's exactly what I love about you."

They ate in silence as night crept in around them. The forest stayed quiet, way too quiet. There was no chirp of crickets, just the feeling of being watched by something ancient and all-

knowing. They'd come here with hopefulness, but the deeper they'd traveled the more unpredictable things had become. It seemed that this wasn't just wild magic, but that it was wounded magic that was unstable and still healing and not sure if it could trust them.

Chapter 4

With the fire crackling low in the pit Catra had circled with stones, their camp almost looked peaceful. Above them, the sky had deepened to a dark lavender with stars beginning to blink between drifting clouds. The glow from the magic flare they'd glimpsed earlier was gone now, no more than a memory of light hanging in the trees.

Adora sat on a rolled cloak with her knees drawn up to her chest. Catra had noticed how little she'd spoken recently.
"You've got that stare again," Catra said softly as she leaned back against a tree with her tail twitching. "You worried the forest won't give us a warm welcome tomorrow?"
Adora glanced at her with wary eyes. "It's not really that."
Catra arched her brow. "Then what is it?"
Adora hesitated and then let the words spill out, "I don't know exactly. It's just something here feels wrong. It's like the magic here is watching me, and I keep thinking about how the Heart released all this magic into the world and maybe it didn't settle like we hoped. What if it's looking for something or maybe someone to latch onto?"
Catra's expression tightened just slightly, but she tried for lightness anyway. "Well, if it's looking to attach itself to some heroic and self-sacrificing type then you are definitely its girl."
Adora let out a soft laugh. "Thanks."

They settled into silence for a while again watching the flickering flames. When the fire began to burn low, Adora pulled on another log and Catra shifted closer, tugging a cloak around both of them.
"You ever think we might finally get to just live?" she asked, voice quiet. "Like, actually live, you know. Not just surviving the next crisis."
Adora leaned in, chin resting comfortably on Catra's shoulder. "I want to believe that."
Catra's hand found hers. "Then believe it just for tonight."
The woods stayed silent, but the tension in the air had thinned at least a little. The crackling firelight faded and for a time there was

only their steady breathing as they drifted to sleep near one another.

Then the ground shivered. It wasn't a quake or tremor, but a hum beneath the surface like a sudden surge of energy.
Adora sat up instantly with her heart hammering. "Did you feel that?"
Catra was already on her feet with her ears flat against her head. "Yeah, something's…"
The forest cut her off with a pulse of shimmering energy that swept through the clearing like a ghostly tide. A shrill sound like a chord pulled too tight rose from nowhere and sliced through the quiet.
Adora didn't hesitate. "For the Honor of Grayskull!" The sword materialized into her hand as she transformed into She-Ra in a blaze of golden-white light. The forest seemed to pull back for a moment. The power rushed through her and she felt steadier and more focused. Then, the magic around them tightened and pulsed.

She-Ra reached out trying to guide the magic and release it like she had with the Heart, but it resisted. It felt chaotic and almost wounded.
"It's not listening," she said, her voice strained. "It's pushing back."
The glow around her intensified, and the air turned heavy as it pressed down on her shoulders. She braced herself and dug in her heels, but the flare snapped. It was sudden and sharp like a whip cracking through the clearing. It hit into her and she gasped and staggered back as the forest erupted in what felt like a soundless scream. Catra shouted something that she couldn't hear.
Then as quickly as it had come on the pressure faded and the air stilled. She collapsed to one knee, panting. Her transformation held but only barely. Sweat trickled down her temple and her hands trembled.

Catra was there in seconds, grabbing her by the shoulders. "Adora! Hey, hey, look at me. What just happened? Are you okay?"

“I..” Adora started, but winced. “I tried to stabilize it, but it wasn’t ready. It lashed out, and I couldn’t stop it.”
Catra’s jaw clenched. “And it hurt you.”
Adora nodded slowly, but then shook her head as if to dismiss it. “Not bad. It just caught me off guard. I’m okay.”
“You are not okay,” Catra snapped, eyes blazing with worry. “You’re shaking.”
She-Ra’s glow dimmed slightly. “I didn’t want it to escalate. I thought I could calm it.”
Catra helped her stand, steadying her with a hand pressed to the small of her back. “Well, next time, try not doing that alone.”
The wind rustled the leaves again. The flare was gone for now, but the message was clear. This magic wasn’t done, and it didn’t trust She-Ra.

Chapter 5

It was the middle of the night now, but neither of them slept. Not yet. Adora lay curled on a cloak. Her transformation had faded not long after the flare with the magic, slipping from her and leaving her drained. Catra however was pacing. Back and forth across the clearing with her tail twitching and ears on edge. Every few seconds she'd glance over at Adora, her eyes dark with worry she couldn't release.

"Are you gonna say something?" Adora asked quietly breaking the silence.
Catra stopped and looked over at her. "I'm thinking."
"That's dangerous," Adora replied trying to lighten the mood.
Catra's mouth twitched, but she didn't smile. "You scared me."
Adora looked down at her arms. "I know."
Catra crossed over and dropped beside her, not quite touching, but close. "You always do this Adora. You think it's your job to fix everything so you run straight at it like a stubborn golden idiot with a sword."
Adora managed a small laugh, but then winced as her body still ached from the magic, "Hurts a bit still."
"Good," Catra said bitterly, her anger still rising. "Maybe you'll stop charging into flare zones without backup."
"I thought I could handle it. I had to try," Adora replied quietly in her own defense.
"You almost got torn apart by magic you barely understand," Catra nearly growled.

Adora didn't answer right away as she gathered her thoughts carefully.
"It didn't want to be released," she murmured eventually. "At least not yet. It's like it was screaming at me and I couldn't understand its words. I thought I could reach it, but it just fought me."
Catra shifted closer and let herself lean toward Adora as her anger released and softness returned. "Maybe it just wasn't ready yet."
Adora gave a small nod, but her eyes were distant and hurt. "Or, maybe I wasn't."

The words hung in the air between them for a moment, and then Catra reached for her hand and curled her fingers around Adora's slowly. "You don't have to prove anything to anyone. Not anymore."
"I'm not trying to prove anything," Adora said, though the words were thin and brittle. "I just… I want to help. I'm supposed to be able to help. That's the whole point of me, isn't it? If I can't even do that…"
"Hey." Catra tugged her gently so they were facing each other. "Stop. You are not just some magical fix-it tool. You're not only useful when you're saving the world."
Adora blinked, something aching behind her eyes. "Then what am I?"
Catra stared at her for another long moment, her eyes softened as she said in a near whisper, "You're mine."
That hit Adora harder than any flare. Her lip trembled and she leaned in with her forehead against Catra's shoulder as her eyes squeezed shut. "I really thought I could do it."
"I know," Catra whispered, holding her. "And you still will. Just not tonight."

They sat like that for a long while, wrapped in the hush of the woods and each other's arms. Above them, stars spilled like silver dust across the sky, and the wind stirred the trees softly once more. Adora exhaled slowly, some of the tension loosening in her chest. Catra rubbed gentle circles into her back, the effect protective and grounding.
"You think the magic will give us another chance?" Adora asked eventually her voice quiet.
"Yeah," Catra said softly. "But next time, let's have a plan and do this together." They curled up more fully, wrapped around one another and let themselves sleep through what remained of the night.

Chapter 6

Pale sunlight lit up the camp in quiet gold. The magic in the air still hummed faintly like a vibration in her bones, but it was calmer now, like it too was waiting. Adora sat cross-legged still wrapped in one of the cloaks. She wasn't fully herself yet with light shadows under her eyes and a fatigue that lingered, but she was steadier this morning. Catra was crouched nearby, sharpening her blade with a slow rhythm, though her eyes kept flicking back to Adora. She was pretending not to be watching her, but Adora could tell.

They sat in silence for a moment listening to the quiet sounds of the woods around them.
"I've been thinking," Adora started with her voice soft, "about last night and that flare."
"Let me guess," Catra said. "You're blaming yourself again."
"I'm not." Adora paused and fidgeted a bit. "Okay, maybe a little. But now I'm thinking more about our plan for how to go about stabilizing it today. You're right that She-Ra can't just go charging in alone."
Catra turned to her, brow furrowed. "Yeah, we're not doing that again."
Adora smiled, faint and tired but real. "I think I need something steadier than myself, like more strength I can pull from."
Catra gave her a sideways glance. "What do you mean?"
"You," Adora said simply. "Your strength. It grounds me, and I think if we could use that somehow it would work."
Catra blinked. "Wow. That's a lot of pressure."
Adora smirked. "Don't worry, you're annoyingly good at it."
Catra bristled, but her hand slid into Adora's and held tight. "Ok then, so you take on the forest and I lend you my strength. Some weird mix of magic, trauma, and existential vines it is, but at least it's a plan where you have backup."
"Yeah, we'll work together like we should have done it the first time," Adora said.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Don’t get mushy on me now. Let’s tell Glimmer what’s up before you start quoting poetry.”

They pulled out their tracker pad and hit the call rune. Glimmer’s face popped up a few seconds later, sleepy but alert.
“You’re calling early,” she said as she brushed a stray strand of hair off her face. “What’s up?”
Adora glanced over at Catra, who gave her an encouraging nod.
“The flare we tried to stabilize last night, it didn’t go as well as we had hoped it would.” She paused to gather her emotions, “I couldn’t release its magic right and it pushed back pretty hard.”
Glimmer frowned in concern. “Are you okay?”
“I’m fine now,” Adora replied quickly and then added, “Just tired. But it’s definitely stronger than we thought.”
“We were overconfident,” Catra added bluntly. “It nearly overwhelmed her.”
“But we have a new plan,” Adora jumped in. “I think we can stabilize it if I’m not doing it alone. We want to try having Catra lend me her strength through a magical connection.”
Glimmer blinked. “You’re serious?”
Catra raised an eyebrow. “You think it won’t work Sparkles?”
“No,” Glimmer said quickly. “I think it’s actually a pretty smart idea.”
Adora smiled.
“I’ll be there soon to help you set this up,” Glimmer added and they ended the call.
Adora leaned into Catra’s side a little more. “Ready to be my magical rock?”
Catra scoffed. “I’m more of a magical cactus really. I’m prickly and resilient.”
Adora laughed, and it was light and real.

A bit later a burst of pink light shimmered through the trees and was followed by the soft thud of boots on grass as Glimmer arrived. Her hair was a little frizzy from teleportation and she had a satchel of supplies swinging from her shoulder. “I brought rune stones and some stabilizer powder. If you’re going to try this magical connection idea, I want it done right.”
Catra stood up immediately, ever wary, though relieved. “How

long do you need?"
"Not long," Glimmer said, already unpacking. "I can set up a tethering ward with one rune stone on you and one on Adora. It should allow you to channel your connection through each other."
"Is this safe?" Catra asked.
"No," Glimmer said bluntly, then softened. "But it's safer than the last thing you tried."
Adora gave a weary laugh. "I'll take it."

Over the next hour, Glimmer moved with focused precision as she marked the runes with magic and gave one to each of them.
"When you use these, you'll need to hold hands or stay in physical contact somehow. The bond stabilizes through connection. It's both emotional and physical," Glimmer explained.
"Touchy-feely magic," Catra muttered.
"Yeah, but it should work," Glimmer said. "Your two have a strong bond, so you might as well use it."
Adora reached over and threaded her fingers through Catra's, and Catra didn't let go.
Glimmer stepped back with a small nod. "Okay. You two are all set. And… be careful, okay?" With another shimmer of light, she vanished.

The forest felt quiet again without the bubbly presence of their friend. Adora leaned her head on Catra's shoulder and let herself breathe deeply, gathering herself for what lay ahead.
"You really are my anchor," she murmured.
"I'd rather be your sword," Catra replied softly. "But I'll take anchor if it means I can keep you safe."
Adora didn't answer with words. Instead she just squeezed Catra's hand and leaned in closer. She felt steadier and more ready now. They had a plan, and they had each other. This time She-Ra wouldn't be facing the forest alone.

Chapter 7

The atmosphere of the forest had begun to shift slowly around them. It had become still and beyond quiet. There was a heaviness in the air and a wrongness that seemed to pulse just beneath the surface of the ground. Catra knelt at the base of an ancient cedar, rechecking the rune-stones Glimmer had carefully enchanted before leaving. The etched symbols still glowed faintly with pale pink lines woven through with glowing gold.

“They’re holding,” Catra said, though the tension in her shoulders suggested otherwise.
Adora stood a pace ahead, transformed into She-Ra and with her sword in hand. Her eyes were on the center of the clearing. It pulsed slowly like it was breathing and the waves of energy coming off it prickled her skin into nervous goosebumps.
"Okay," Adora said, swallowing hard. "You lend me your strength through the anchor runes. Just help me hold steady."
“Just don’t push too hard,” Catra added tensely as she placed her hand onto her shoulder.

Adora nodded and then reached out toward the magic. At first, she felt nothing, but then the flare responded with sudden intensity. It was like a hand that reached out and then clenched. A flash of light rippled through the clearing and the runes shuddered. Adora gasped as the magic lanced through her, not burning exactly, but pressing. It was a pressure like weight and heat and noise all at once. So strong that her knees buckled.
“Adora!” Catra’s voice was sharp, and the connection between them snapped into focus through the rune-stones.
“I’m,” Adora started to speak between pants, and then gritted her teeth, “I’m fine.”
“No, you’re not.” Catra leaned toward her. “That’s not the flare just reacting. It’s trying to crush you.”

Adora’s sword blazed brighter as she tried to use their combined strength to push back against the pressure, but it only seemed to make the flare pulse harder in return. The air hummed with fury.

The magic wouldn't let her help, instead it rejected her. Her body locked up and her lungs stuttered.
"Adora!" Catra's voice broke through the tension gripping her now with both hands. "Breathe! Look at me!"
Adora's eyes snapped open. Catra's face hovered inches away with panic carved into every line. The light of her sword had dimmed. The flare pulsed around them one more time and then it pushed. A shockwave of heat and force flung them both backward. Adora landed hard on her back with the breath punched from her lungs, and her transformation having faded. Catra rolled and skidded landing in a feline crouch in the dirt, a low curse escaping her.

Adora groaned, propping herself up on trembling arms, and Catra was beside her in a heartbeat, anxiously asking, "You okay?"
Adora nodded, though her chest felt hollow and she panted trying to catch her breath. "It… it didn't want to let me help."
"No kidding," Catra muttered, then immediately softening her tone, added, "Sorry. I just…"
"I know." Adora's voice was barely a whisper. "I thought we could stabilize it. That it would let us help release it, and I…" She broke off, swallowing hard.
Catra reached out for her. "You almost passed out. That flare didn't just reject you, Adora. It fought you."
"I know," she whispered again, looking down at her hands. They were shaking. "I don't want to do this again. Not like this."
"Me either," Catra said fiercely, and then softer, "We're just not ready, not with just runes and hope."
Adora dropped her head against Catra's shoulder, exhausted and saddened. Catra wrapped her in a tight hug, still trying to lend her strength.

Chapter 8

The halls of Bright Moon were warm and bright, but Adora felt the weight of failure clinging to her like wet cloth. It was midafternoon when they arrived having been teleported back by Glimmer in a shimmer of violet light that Adora had barely even felt. Her limbs were heavy and her senses dulled. Catra walked beside her with one hand resting lightly against her back as they stepped through the palace.

The Princess Alliance was already gathered in the council chamber, and they all turned as Glimmer, Catra, and Adora entered.
"Hey," Bow said, rising to greet them. His smile was kind and solid. It was the sort of warmth Adora didn't think she deserved right now.
"How did it go?" Perfuma asked, a little too quickly. Then, catching their expressions, she added softly, "Or… not great then?"
Adora shook her head with her jaw tight. "We tried to stabilize the flare twice, but I couldn't release its magic."
"It was hostile," Catra added flatly.
The silence that followed settled like dust. No one said we were counting on you or why didn't it work, but the words still hung there unsaid. Frosta shifted her weight, Mermista sighed, and even Glimmer's expression held something taut behind her eyes. It hurt more than Adora expected. After a brief moment Glimmer stepped forward. "Okay. We learn and we regroup. Let's figure out what didn't work, and what we can still do."

The meeting ended and Glimmer walked with Adora and Catra to the library. Sunlight streamed in through the tall windows and dust drifted in the beams. The place smelled faintly of ink and spell dust.
"We used the runestones exactly like you said," Catra grumbled as she paced along the edge of a map table. "It just wasn't enough, and the flare still threw us both back."
"The connection didn't hold?" Glimmer asked with concern.
"It held," Adora murmured. "But the flare didn't want to be

calmed. It pushed back like it saw us as a threat."
"Definitely felt like it was defending itself," Catra added.
"Then we need something stronger to contain it," Glimmer said as she flipped open a thick spellbook. "Not just the rune-stones, but a magical bridge that will be a way to channel the magic rather than suppress it."
"More magic?" Catra asked uneasily.
"Both more and different," Glimmer replied.
Adora sat heavily on the bench beside the table and her shoulders slumped. "I just wanted to help."
Catra dropped down beside her so that their shoulders touched. "You are helping. It's just harder than we thought."
"So, you're not disappointed?" Adora asked wide eyed.
"No, I'm furious," Catra spat out. "Angry at the flare and at magic and at how stubborn you are when you get hurt and won't stop." Her voice softened. "But not disappointed. You're still breathing, and I'll take that over a win any day." Catra leaned her head onto Adora's shoulder.
Glimmer was already pulling out chalk and drawing out spell symbols.

An hour passed in quiet concentration. The sun sank low and painted the vaulted ceiling in shades of gold. The only sound was the rustle of parchment as Glimmer worked through the right spell. Adora sat cross-legged on the floor, leaning back on her hands with her head tilted toward the light. Catra lounged next to her, tail twitching
"I still don't get how this magic can use our bond," Catra muttered. "It's not like we hung a sign that says soul-bonded, please approach with caution."
Adora laughed. "It must just know somehow."
"Magic doesn't need a sign," Glimmer said without looking up. "You're connected emotionally, so when you're in sync it creates a stabilizing current like an energy flowing between you in both directions."
"I liked it better when the magic was just a glowing sword," Catra said, but there was a hint of a smile.
Glimmer tapped a complex chalked symbol. "I think this will work

as it uses both a focus point and a containment spell. Adora then anchors the power and Catra you stabilize it. If it works then the flare should release without surging."
Adora's tiredness slipped away at this new hope and she asked eagerly, "So we test it?"

Glimmer nodded and led them into an empty stone-walled chamber. She drew the spell symbol onto the runes and laid them in careful arcs and then handed each of them a crystal link on a leather cord.
Catra eyed hers warily. "This feels like it's going to explode."
"Not if you're careful," Glimmer said with a knowing smile.
The moment both crystals touched their skin, a faint hum sparked between them. It wasn't dramatic, but just a low and steady warmth threading just under their skin.
"That feels new," Catra murmured.
"It's like it's listening," Adora added.
Glimmer exhaled in relief. "Then we're close. We'll need to refine it, test it against a controlled flare…"

She didn't get to fully finish her thought as
the door to the chamber burst open, and Bow skidded in with wide eyes.
"There's another flare," he said tightly, waving his tracker pad. "Its signal is highly erratic and it's pushing toward a coastal village with speed. They've started evacuating."
Adora was on her feet before he finished speaking. "How long do we have?" she asked apprehensively.
"Hours maybe," Bow said with concern. "But not much more."
Glimmer's face darkened with resolve. "We'll take what we've built and reinforce it if needed when we get there. It sounds like we can't wait."
Catra caught Adora's eye, the meaning clear between them. They weren't totally ready, and the magic wasn't fully tested, but they really had no choice. Adora took Catra's hand and gave it a firm squeeze. "Then we go now."

Chapter 9

The wind along the southern coast of Etheria carried the off scent of salt mingled with smoke. The sea breeze should have been crisp and fresh, but now it was scorched and tainted by the flare. A crimson shimmer stained the horizon where the unstable magic pulsed. Glimmer had teleported them to the cliffside overlook just above the village. From there, they could see the damage spreading rapidly below. A line of flickering flame had quickly burned its way through the tall grasses, and it was now heading toward the cluster of thatched rooftops and wooden buildings as smoke billowed thickly into the sky.

"They got everyone out in time," Bow said with relief, scanning the village through his tech-enhanced binoculars. He then added earnestly, "But if we don't stop this, there won't be anything left for them to come back to."
Adora said nothing. Her jaw was tight, her eyes fixed on the flare as it pulsed near the village, glowing like something angry that refused to die.
Catra watched her with narrowed eyes. "We need to get the runes down. You're not going in without this magic in place."
They moved fast. Glimmer and Bow laid the rune crystals in a circle at the flare's perimeter, channeling power into the framework they'd tested that morning. Adora stood in the center, bracing herself as she reached toward the magic. The rune link on her wrist hummed and Catra's matching one pulsed in reply, the energy between them strong and ready.

Adora called on her power and transformed with light glowing upward and sword appearing in her hand.
"I've got you Adora," Catra said softly, trying to ground her, as she stood just outside the circle.
Adora nodded once and stepped toward the flare. The world around her bent with heat. Magic surged up to meet her, and it was wild and wounded and twisting in confusion. She reached out, not with force, but with heart and understanding. She could feel the pain in it, like a sense of betrayal and panic. She called to

it gently and offered it safety and balance. It lashed out anyway. The flare surged upward, a towering arc of light and fury that snapped the anchoring rune on her left. Catra stumbled back with a hiss.
"It's too much!" Glimmer shouted. "It's overloading the containment runes…"
Adora grit her teeth and stepped forward again, even as the magic shoved her back. Her boots dug into the earth. She tried again to soothe it, call it back down, but the flare wasn't listening. It was panicking, like a wild creature trying to escape a trap. And then suddenly, it broke free.

The explosion was more of a collapse than a blast, like a star caving in on itself. Magic burst outward in all directions, radiant and chaotic. Then the flare burned out in an instant, like a candle blown too hard. When the light faded, the damage had been done. Half the village was in ruin with blackened wood, scorched roofs, and homes turned to rubble. It looked like the charred remains of a firestorm. Adora stood still in the silence after the blast. Her transformation faded slowly and she knelt in the dirt.

Glimmer and Bow rushed to check and confirmed again that all the evacuees were safe.
But Catra didn't move with them, her eyes were locked on Adora.
"Hey," she said quietly, stepping closer. "You stopped it, and no one got hurt."
Adora's voice was barely audible. "It wasn't enough."
"You didn't fail…"
"I couldn't save it," she gestured with a wave of her hand to the vast destruction. Her eyes were glassy with exhaustion and disbelief, and her shoulders sagged like something inside her had unraveled. "I had my power and Glimmer's magic and your strength," Adora murmured, staring at the smoking remains. "And it still wasn't enough."
Catra walked forward and took her hand. "I know," she said softly. "But you don't have to carry this on your own." Adora leaned against her slowly, too tired to argue. Catra wrapped her arms around her and held her there, grounding her the way the runes had not. It felt like it was the only thing she could do.

Above them, the sky was beginning to darken. Smoke painted dark streaks across the pink and orange clouds, and the air felt thick with everything unsaid. They had stopped the flare, but not stabilized it and what had been lost Adora would not soon be able to forget.

Chapter 10

Moonlight painted silver streaks across the stone floor of their room, slipping through gauzy curtains and falling over tangled blankets and discarded boots. Outside, Bright Moon was peacefully quiet, but inside their room, the silence was thick almost too heavy to rest in. It felt too full of everything they weren't saying. Adora lay facing the wall, knees pulled toward her chest as if she could somehow shield her heart with her limbs. Her back was to Catra, shoulders trembling under the soft linen sheet. The quiet shudder of her breath should have passed for sleep, but it wasn't.

Adora curled in on herself, her hands gripping her pillow as the tears came hot and fast. Soft sobs rippling through her with each painful thought that coursed through her of her own inadequacy. Why was everything she did never enough? The unsubdued flare, the ruined village, the look in the villagers' eyes when they'd returned to nothing but scorched buildings, all pressed against her like a weight she couldn't push off. She had given everything, and it still hadn't been enough to save what mattered.

Catra lay beside her, motionless, staring at the ceiling. She hadn't said anything when they got back. She hadn't asked how Adora was doing because she already knew. She had read it in her posture and the numb way she'd walked through the halls to their room and climbed into bed without a word. And now, she heard the small shudders of someone trying not to cry too loudly, trying not to make it worse for anyone else. Catra's chest ached, hearing those sad soft sounds beside her, unsure of what she could do. Her own insecurities stirred under her skin. Fears she rarely admitted to, even now. That she didn't know how to help, and she wasn't enough either, at least not when it mattered most.

Catra's hand hesitated above the blanket, fingers twitching with uncertainty. But then she reached out and brushed a few strands of hair back from Adora's tear-damp face. She didn't speak. She didn't try to fix it. She just slipped her arm gently around Adora's

waist and wordlessly pulled her closer, pressing her forehead to the space between Adora's shoulder blades. Letting her know she was there, providing what little comfort she could.

Adora didn't resist, but sagged into the touch, burying her face in her pillow as another wave of tears came. But her breathing steadied just a little. The sobs dulled into quiet tremors.
"I'm here," Catra whispered eventually, barely audible. "You don't have to hold it all alone."
Adora didn't respond. But her hand reached back slowly to grasp Catra's arm where it circled her and she held tight. In that tangle of moonlight and sorrow, they stayed as two hearts trying to hold each other steady against a world that still needed saving.

Chapter 11

Morning light filtered in soft and golden as it brushed across the stone walls of their room and shimmered on the floor. It felt too gentle and too peaceful for how heavy Adora's chest still felt. She sat on the edge of the bed in clean clothes with her hair pulled up and in place, but her back was hunched and her elbows were braced on her knees trying to ease the weight pressing in on her ribs. Catra was quiet as she readied for the day, though her ears were pressed back slightly and twitched now and then toward Adora watching her carefully.

"You don't have to say anything," Adora said suddenly, voice low and hoarse. "I know what you're thinking."
Catra paused for a moment, but then acknowledged what she knew Adora was getting at, "I don't think you failed Adora"
"People lost everything yesterday, Catra. And I couldn't stop it. I was She-Ra, and I couldn't do a damn thing."
"You think that was your fault?" Catra's voice was quieter now, sharper in its softness. "You think you didn't do enough?"
Adora looked up, eyes rimmed red. "Isn't it? If I'd just pushed harder…"
"You pushed until you nearly collapsed," Catra said, reaching down to cup her cheek. "You've been pushing since the day you touched that sword. But you can't always fix everything every time."
Adora blinked hard. "I just… I thought I could."
"I know," Catra murmured. "So did I."
Catra pressed her forehead to Adora's, and they stayed that way for a moment taking a shared breath in the early light in the space between grief and motion. Then Catra pulled back and offered her a hand. "Come on. You don't have to smile for them, but you should be there."
Adora nodded and took her hand and together they stepped into the day.

The council chamber was quieter than usual. Bright Moon's white stone walls sparkled with lingering magic, but it felt dimmer today and more subdued. Tension weighed on every shoulder like a

cloak too heavy to shrug off. Glimmer sat at the head of the table with an air of authority and right beside her Bow stared down at the readings on his tracker. Frosta stood at the table's edge, her stance restless and conveying her want to take action. Mermista leaned back in her chair with her arms crossed, her slouched posture hiding the tightness in her jaw as she prepared for another round of bad news. Perfuma sat forward, hands clasped on the table, shoulders tense but angled toward the others as she tried to project calm even as worry tightened her frame. Netossa and Spinnerella exchanged glances as the door creaked open. No one smiled as Catra and Adora entered.

"Hey," Glimmer said softly. "You okay?"
"I'm here," Adora said after a pause as she slid into her seat. "Let's just talk about what comes next."
Bow cleared his throat. "We've been getting more readings of flares appearing. They seem to be spreading."
"We need to use more force," Frosta said, slamming a fist into her palm. "Trap them in ice."
"Because fighting it has worked so well so far?" Glimmer's tone was weary but firm. "We tried that. We threw everything we could at the last flare and we still lost that village."
Adora closed her eyes for a moment and beneath the table Catra's hand squeezed hers.
"Maybe it's not about containing or fighting it," Perfuma suggested. "Maybe it's about listening and understanding what it wants."
"Even if it's angry?" Adora asked. "Even if it's destroying things?"
"Especially then," Spinnerella added.
Adora's gaze drifted over the map of the new flares, her voice quiet but steady. "Then we need a new plan. We need something that doesn't just hold it back, but something that heals its anger."
Glimmer nodded. "We'll figure out a new way."

Later that day, the council chamber was filled with a few low voices. Adora stood near the wide window with her arms crossed tight over her chest. Beyond the glass, Bright Moon's hills rolled green and peaceful with brilliantly colored wildflowers swaying in the wind as if nothing had gone wrong. As if the magic she had

released wasn't threatening Etheria.
Bow's voice pulled her back to the present. "The flares are too strong and we need more than a magical anchor and containment runes. We need some type of stabilization source."
"Or maybe an energy diffuser," Glimmer added with her hands sparkling as she thought about which spell might work best. "Something to ease the pressure before it erupts."

Adora turned from the window remembering what Perfuma had said. "We need to heal the source though, not just hold it down."
"You tried reaching it," Glimmer said gently. "You gave everything you had."
"And it wasn't enough," Adora shot back her frustration rising. "I wasn't enough."
"You need to stop saying that," Catra said softly but fierce from her spot leaning back against the table.
"It's true," Adore replied quickly clenching her hand into a fist at her side.
"No," Catra countered, stepping closer. "You didn't fail. We all went out there together and we all faced it. You risked everything trying to reach it. That's not failure."
"But the village…"
"It wasn't your fault," Catra cut in. "You think I don't know what it's like to lie awake thinking about what I couldn't stop?"

Adora's shoulders eased slightly, the fight in her voice thinning to something more fragile. "There has to be a way to do this."
"There might be," Bow said, picking up again. "What if we used some type of reflective shield? Not to trap it, but to show it what it is."
Glimmer's brows drew together. "Like a magical mirror."
Bow nodded. "It's reacting blindly with its anger and pain. If we give it a reflection maybe it will break the loop long enough for us to reach it."
Adora looked at him slowly, something sparking in her expression. "A moment of vulnerability." She moved to the table, resting her hands on the edge. "Let's make this plan work."
Glimmer met her eyes. "We will. But Adora… please don't lose yourself trying to fix everything. We need you too."

Adora didn’t reply right away. But Catra’s fingers brushed hers and she nodded slowly.
“I’ll do my best,” she answered.

Chapter 12

The mid-day sun filtered through the clouds as the best friend squad gathered at the flare site. Light winds stirred up the long grasses. This flare pulsed steadily beneath the surface, less violent than the last, but still unpredictable. It was like a heartbeat out of rhythm with the world around it. Adora crouched near the rocky outcrop where the magical reading had been strongest. Her palm hovered just above the warm stone where a gentle golden glow shimmered intermittently. It's magic hummed quietly.

Adora glanced over her shoulder at the others. "Feels restless," she said, eyes narrowing. "Not angry, but unsettled."
Catra stood just behind her, with her arms crossed but her shoulders relaxed, and her voice dry. "Same way you get when you skip breakfast."
Adora let out half a laugh that eased some of her tension and stood. "Maybe it just needs something to stabilize it for a moment to let it reflect so it can heal."
Glimmer stepped up beside them with a nod, "Okay, I'll cast the reflection spell and then She-Ra can channel the calmed magic into release."
"Sounds perfect," Bow said, checking his tracker pad readings. "I'll be monitoring the energy levels the whole time. Any spike and we shut it down."
Adora gave a small, quiet nod as she reached for her sword. Her transformation came smoothly, and light swept over her as She-Ra stood tall and steady with eyes bright. "Let's do this," she said.

The flare stirred as soon as they began with its magical pulse beneath the earth responding to their presence. Glimmer cast her spell, and the flare calmed a bit as if surprised not to be met with force.
She-Ra knelt again, placing her hand gently against the stone. "It's listening," she whispered. She let her magic flow, not pushing or commanding, but just offering assistance. The flare wavered once with a ripple of uncertainty, and Catra stepped forward, resting her hand on She-Ra's back.

“She’s got you,” Catra said to the flare, voice firm but quiet. “You can trust her.”
It was almost imperceptible the way the pulse steadied and then its hum shifted into harmony with She-Ra’s own magic.
Bow let out a low whistle as he monitored the readings. “It’s working.”
“It’s more than working,” Glimmer added as she crouched beside him, her eyes widening. “It’s holding.”
A minute passed and then another as the light from the flare dimmed and the magic flowed into the ground like a breath finally exhaled. When She-Ra stood and let her magic ease back, the flare didn’t resist as it had been released.

For a long moment, no one spoke. Then Glimmer grinned. “We did it.”
Adora smiled, and for once, it was not the wary kind she’d worn for the past few days, but a real one that was wide and bright and full of quiet joy and relief. “We actually did.”
Bow threw his arms up in triumph. “That’s what I’m talking about! Zero injuries! Zero crisis!”
Catra rolled her eyes, but she was smiling too. “You’re going to jinx it.”
“Let him have this,” Adora murmured, stepping close to Catra and letting her shoulder brush gently against hers. “We all needed this.”
And she wasn’t just saying it. She felt it in her chest and in the soft magic that lingered around the flare like a contented sigh. It had worked this time for real. The magic had paused and trusted her and let itself release. It was because they had trusted each other with this plan, and the reflection spell had given the magic enough space to see its own vulnerability and heal. The four of them stood together for a while longer with their arms wound around each other’s shoulders, just breathing in the relief of this success.

Chapter 13

Two days later, the friends readied to return to the forest where the first flare had been spotted nearly a week before. Adora and Catra had abandoned it after two failed attempts, and though the new method had been quite a success on the last flare, Adora knew that this one was much more volatile from those earlier encounters. But, she also knew they had to try to subdue this flare before it could do real lasting damage.

The pink magical sparks dissipated as Glimmer teleported the group into the forest, close to where Bow had tracked the strongest magical signature. They blinked rapidly, adjusting from the glowing halls of Bright Moon to the darkness of the forest. It was late morning, but only a few crisp beams of sunlight made it through the thick canopy of trees which now surrounded them, towering, twisted and ancient. They were at once majestic and mystical and also foreboding. And, just as before, the air felt thick with magic, too still and too quiet, like all signs of other life had fled. The ground itself seemed to vibrate with power. Adora felt her pulse quicken as she remembered her last two attempts to subdue this flare and its prior intensity. The warm touch of a hand on her shoulder instantly grounded her a bit. It was Catra sidling up beside her with an expression belying a confidence she didn't fully feel, but knew Adora needed right now.

"Good to be back with our favorite tree friends," Catra snarked, trying to keep the mood light.
Glimmer readied herself to cast the reflection spell and said, "This time we've got this."
Bow stood right beside her and gave a nod of confirmation. "The magical signature is getting even stronger. We're going to need to act soon."
Adora reached her hand up to summon her magic. Her brow furrowed as she concentrated and pushed past fear as she'd done so many times before. Warmth and light surrounded her as she transformed and was filled with the full power of She-Ra, and she raised her sword high.

A sudden discordant sound filled the forest and echoed all around them. She-Ra's magic-bright eyes darted from one massive tree trunk to the next, looking for a source, as sweat beaded on her brow. The vibrations in the ground intensified, and a sharp wave of light raced toward them like a supernova unfurling. Glimmer rooted herself in place and cast the reflection spell directly into the center of the exploding violet light. As the spell made contact, the wave of light seemed to seize up, trembling and slowing its pace. Pausing as it was forced to look within itself. Then, She-Ra took a deep, steadying breath and stepped forward toward the shimmering glow. She could feel the intensity of the heat and pressure still emanating from the flare. Still, she kept her sword low and instead raised her hand toward the wavering field of light, letting her magic flow toward it in a gesture of help and not control. She could feel its wounded energy flickering, its uncertainty. Catra stepped up behind her and pressed a hand between her shoulder blades, lending her strength and support. The magic seemed to sense now that they were there to help, and it began to trust and to dim. The light seemed to shimmer and then melt almost into the forest floor.

"The magical interference is reducing," Bow called out enthusiastically.
Glimmer added excitedly, "It's releasing, just like we hoped."
Adora could feel it too, and a small smile appeared as she continued to channel the power of the flare into the ground harmoniously. But then she felt a tension as the last bits of the flaring magic pressed against her hand, and she stiffened suddenly.
"Adora?" Catra questioned in concern, "Are you alright?" Then she added, trying to strengthen Adora to be able to finish what they'd started, "You've got this. It's almost fully released." And, to the last tendrils of shimmering and pulsing magic, she added, "Just trust her. She's helping you."
Adora didn't reply. The magic tendrils pushed against her hand with increasing intensity, and she tried to soothe her mind and focus on healing release, but all she could feel in that moment was fear, her own fear that she would fail against this flare once

again. And, as that thought filled her mind, she pulled suddenly with her magic and forced the last tendrils of the flare's energy directly into herself. A wave of overwhelming distress at what she had just done filled her.

"The readings have fully stabilized," Bow called out joyfully as he hugged Glimmer.
"Well, I guess the forest ghosts weren't all they were cracked up to be after all," Catra added as she stepped back toward them. Adora could barely even hear the voices of her friends through the clouds of her own mind, but she forced a smile and a steady outward veneer. She quickly let her transformation fade before anyone could notice her hesitation.

Chapter 14

They returned to Bright Moon, with its golden afternoon light streaming through the large and familiar gothic arched windows, and Adora felt out of place and unsettled. This castle was like a home to her, and it usually held comfort for her, but Adora couldn't seem to feel any of it right now. Instead, her body seemed to thrum with the wrongness of the memory of what she had absorbed. She walked alongside her friends, their footsteps echoing off the polished floors, but the sound felt hollow to her ears. Catra reached for her hand, and Adora flinched for a moment before returning the squeeze. Catra quirked an eyebrow at her but then let it drop, bumping their shoulders together affectionately, "You did good."

By the time they reached the dining hall, Glimmer had already decided they were going to celebrate. "We earned this," she declared while leading the way to a table already being set with platters of food. "Let's enjoy a victory meal before we jump back into planning for the next flare."
Adora sat down with them, trying to let the warmth of the moment settle in. She chewed and swallowed like normal, but she didn't taste a single bite of the food. She hid her hands in her lap to hide their faint tremor.
"It's wild we were only gone a few hours," Bow exclaimed cheerfully, "That release was so intense, it felt like we were out there all day, but we did such a good job with it."
"Yeah, the reflection spell just made the explosion stop in its tracks." Glimmer declared proudly.
Catra smirked and said, "I'm sure you guys are giving a totally unbiased report."

They laughed together, and Adora laughed along with them, but hers was a bit forced. Before anyone could notice, she added quickly, "Yeah, it went…it went really well." Her insides twisted at the words. She wanted to believe them, but to her, it felt like it had actually not gone well at all.
Bow leaned towards her and gave her shoulder a friendly nudge,

“You did amazing out there, Adora.”
Adora’s throat tightened as she nodded along, with a small, too tight smile. “Yeah, I’m just glad it’s over.” The words flowed out, but their weight clung heavily in her chest. She knew that it wasn’t really over, at least not fully. The memory of what might be inside her filled her mind. She knew she should tell her friends what had really happened. That she had accidentally absorbed some of the flare. But, as she looked at their bright, smiling faces, she couldn’t bring herself to steal the peace they had earned away from them. She didn’t want to make another problem that they’d have to deal with, another burden.

Later that evening, the four of them gathered in the council chamber around the central table. A projected map of Etheria’s terrain glowed in soft pink. The flare markers stood out against it, blinking in angry red. Adora’s stomach dropped as she counted them. There were still so many out there, and it seemed like three more had appeared just in one day. They were definitely appearing more frequently now.
“There are more flares,” Bow said lowly, but then added with optimism, “But we have a way to stop them now.”
Glimmer leaned against his shoulder and added with determination, “Yeah, we’ll just work through them one at a time.”
“We’ll figure this out,” Adora heard herself say, forcing her voice steady. “We’ve handled worse.” Her words sounded sure, but inside her thoughts gnawed at her. She wondered if the magic she had absorbed was somehow leaking out and affecting Etheria more than ever, and increasing the number of flares.

Night fell, and Adora lay beside Catra in their bed in Bright Moon, moonlight streaking silver across the floor. Catra was curled beside her, already asleep, but Adora’s thoughts still raced. What had she done? She knew that she had made a mistake, but she had to believe she could still fix it. She just needed to fix this. Then a terrible thought flickered into her mind. Was the magic she carried inside her now dangerous? Could it spill out and hurt Catra? Her chest tightened at that thought. Fear of what might come from what she had done gripped her. For the first time since she’d almost failed at the Heart, Adora felt afraid that she wouldn’t be

able to fix this. That she was failing once again. Adora squeezed her eyes shut and struggled to push the thoughts away. The shadows in the room seemed to grow ever longer as her thoughts spiraled darker. But eventually, she fell into a restless sleep.

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's mind swirled in a haze of half-formed thoughts and fractured images as she drifted into a dream. She shifted into an endless expanse of darkened sky where the air hummed with an ethereal energy. She floated in the middle of nothingness as sparkling deep violet tendrils of magic twirled toward her. Everywhere she looked, the magic fractured into sudden bursts that flared bright and then scattered in violent sparks across the expanse. Adora wrapped her arms around herself and searched for something solid, but she was surrounded by only darkness and the approaching flaring crackles of magic.

It seemed like she was facing the magic that now lived within her. Adora’s throat tightened and her eyes cast downwards as she admitted with a shaking voice, “I made a mistake. I pulled some of the magic I was meant to release into myself instead.”
A voice, strange and mystical, filled the air.
“Mistakes open doors strength cannot.”
A tendril of purplish magic, not sparking now but softer, drifted toward her, and Adora realized with a soft gasp that it was the magic itself speaking to her.
The deep, enigmatic voice continued, “What you absorbed is not a curse. It is the key.”
Adora shook her head, not able to fully grasp what she was being told. “No, you don’t understand. I have some of the flare magic inside me just waiting to hurt someone, or maybe it’s already hurting Etheria.” Her panic was quickly growing, her chest tightened, and her heart pounded with her admissions.
The lightly swirling magic expanded around her, filling her vision with bright purple light, and then softened as it spoke again, “No, all you carry now is understanding.”

Adora's fear began to mingle with something more like hope. Could it really be that absorbing the flare hadn't been a curse after all?
The resonant voice continued, "The magic was freed, but the infection remained."
Adora's stomach knotted. "That's what the flares are? The infection Prime left behind?"
The nearby magic seemed to pulse in agreement, and in the distance, a spark flared and crackled violently in confirmation of the pain still suffered. Soft tendrils of glowing violet mist danced around Adora once more, and the rich, low-toned voice stated, "Understanding can lead to a cure." The magic brightened suddenly in a flash of purple light and then disappeared, leaving her in total darkness for a moment.

Adora woke with a soft gasp. Her eyes fluttered open to take in the dim early morning light just starting to drift in through the window. She lay still for a moment with thoughts of the dream tumbling through her mind with warring emotions, and the feel of Catra breathing softly beside her beginning to ground her a bit. She turned and brushed a hair from Catra's face as she whispered, "Catra," trying to wake her gently.
Stirring lightly, Catra let out a sleepy sound as she blinked awake. "Sun's barely up," she protested lightly, but when she saw the odd look on Adora's face, she became more alert and asked, "What is it? Is something wrong?"
Adora's throat tightened as she felt a mix of emotions at once, the lingering clarity and hope from the dream mingling still with the guilt of what she'd been hiding. She swallowed hard and then said softly in a low whisper, "I need to tell you something." She glanced down at her hands, which trembled faintly, "Something I should have told you right away."

At those words, Catra was filled with a wave of concern, and her eyes narrowed as she nodded tightly for Adora to continue.
Taking in a shaky breath, Adora resumed speaking softly, "At the end of the release yesterday, I accidentally absorbed some of the magic into me instead of releasing it fully." Her eyes cast down, ashamed a bit still of what she'd had done but more so now of

having hid it. “I’ve been so scared of what this magic in me might do. That it might hurt something.”
For a heavy moment, Catra stared at Adora, absorbing this information, but then she let out a low sigh and cupped Adora’s cheek and stroked it tenderly. “You’ve only been hurting yourself by keeping this hidden.”
Adora’s eyes stung, and a few tears leaked down her cheeks as she exhaled softly and let herself lean into Catra’s comfort, always so steady even when she felt she least deserved it. It gave her the strength to press on. “I had a dream just now, but it was more than a dream really. The magic I absorbed... it spoke to me.”
Catra’s eyes widened at that, and she asked tightly, “What did it say?”
“The flares are happening because Prime’s infection still lingered in the magic I released from the Heart. And, what I absorbed yesterday isn’t going to hurt me or anyone else, it just let me connect to the magic.” Relief flooded through Adora as she let herself truly believe these words and release her fears from the past day. She continued to speak with new hope and confidence filling her chest, “I think we can cure the magical infection and stop all the flares for good.”

Chapter End Notes

Check out my Tumblr for art I made for this story: https://www.tumblr.com/notmydestiny

Chapter 16

The Whispering Woods opened up into a wide path, the ground etched deeply with the remains of First Ones' symbols. The Best Friend Squad headed forward together, toward the place where Catra had once seen Horde Prime release his infection into Etheria. As they approached, rocky formations opened steadily into a faceted diamond-like shape carved deep into the surface of the planet. Rising high above, a dormant green crystal topped twisting metal beams above curving black and silver metallic structures that towered over them, remnants left by Horde Prime.

Stepping forward, Catra's ears twitched, and she said, "This place still feels wrong."
Bow nodded grimly, "This is where Prime infected Etheria, so this is where we end this."
"And we will," Glimmer confirmed, her tone sharp with determination.
Adora nodded, "Let's do this."
As Adora stepped toward the structure, she felt hopeful now that they would be able to cure the infection and end the flares for good. Her eyes glowed brightly as she raised her hand and called forth her magic, her form bathed in light as she transformed into She-Ra. She knelt by the structure and pressed her palms to the surface of the planet, light emanating from her and absorbing into the ground.

Glimmer shattered a vial of crushed crystal and drew into the air the intricate pattern for the healing spell and thrust it into the lit-up ground. With these combined healing magics, tendrils of green light began to flow through the etchings in the ground and back upward through the towering structure of twisted metal. Adora channeled all of her concentration into focusing her power into the land. She could feel the magic of Etheria humming within the surface beneath her and then entwined within it, the shadows of something tainted, the infection tangled within that flow. It was seeping out now and coursing back to its source.

But then, it seemed to slow, and as her pulse quickened, Adora reflexively pushed harder with her magic. Her breathing became more strained, and she clenched her jaw. The magic's pain became her pain. Its struggle was her struggle. A wave of exhaustion passed through her, and with it the fear that she would fail. Adora took in a steadying breath and allowed that fear to fully wash over her, to be a part of her. She knew now that her fear wasn't weakness; it was just another force, like the magic itself. She wasn't losing, she was learning.

The glow from She-Ra's palms faded for a moment as she allowed herself to surrender and listen to the pulse of Glimmer's healing spell working alongside her. She let the flow of the magic become less about forcing change and more about nurturing what already wanted to heal. The light from her hands glowed once more, but this time it was steady and soft. It wrapped around the infection, not overpowering it, but instead encouraging it to recede. The green glow increased once more, flowing with speed into the metallic structure and up into the crystal at its center. The emerald-like diamond glowed blindingly, pulsed and then went dormant once more.

The air felt clearer now, as if the land itself had exhaled a deep breath after a long, painful struggle. Adora stood, her chest still heaving, but a sense of peace settling over her as she released her transformation and let She-Ra shift to Adora. She heard the familiar sounds of footsteps as Glimmer, Bow, and Catra appeared beside her. Glimmer's gaze softened as she stepped forward, her usual bright energy tempered by a quiet pride. "Adora... you did it. The infection's gone. You can feel it, right?"
Adora nodded with a small smile. She was tired, but at the same time, exhilarated. The healing magic had worked.
"Yeah," Adora breathed out, her voice filled with quiet awe. "It feels... better. Like the planet is free again."

Bow, standing right beside Glimmer, pulled out his tracker pad, and his fingers moved quickly over the screen. He scanned it with a furrowed brow, tapping the surface a few times to zoom in on the map and readings. "The flare signals across Etheria, they're all

gone now. Curing the infection has resolved them all.” He smiled widely, letting out a relieved sigh. "Looks like everything is back to normal and fully stabilized."
Glimmer stepped forward, her hands gently resting on Adora’s shoulders. “That’s a relief. We all knew you could do it, but seeing it... it’s incredible.”
Adora glanced over at Bow, her own brow furrowed with a bit of lingering doubt. “You’re sure, right, no more flare signals?”
“Not even a trace," Bow confirmed, swiping across the tracker one last time. “There’s nothing left. Etheria’s magic is back in balance. All the corrupted zones, every last one of them, are gone.“

Before Adora could respond, Catra, who had been hanging back slightly, stepped forward. There was still something in her posture, her stance almost guarded, but the edge was gone, replaced by approval. Her eyes shifted between Prime’s structure and Adora’s exhausted face, and for a moment, the two locked gazes. Catra watched Adora with a mix of pride and something softer in her eyes. “You really did it this time, Adora.” Catra cupped her cheek, and Adora leaned into her touch.

Catra’s steadying hand reminded Adora that she didn’t have to hide her flaws, that they were part of what made her whole. Just like the flares had needed a moment of reflection to be vulnerable enough to be helped, Adora had too. The peace she found now wasn’t the absence of mistakes, but the acceptance that mistakes were part of the path forward. That sometimes they were her strength. Adora now realized that just as Etheria was blooming more than it had in over a thousand years, she too was ready to stumble, to grow, to bloom.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!